

Chapter 173-1

Liang Shi never expected to trend on hot search at such a critical juncture.

And it was with the hashtag #TrueAndFakeHeiress#.

This wasn't beneficial for Liang Xinran at all.

After "Let's Go Right Now" aired, her reputation had been very good. As long as she maintained her current popularity and reputation, resources would definitely come looking for her after the variety show finished filming. Moreover, her management contract was under the media company that Liang Xinzhou had acquired.

Liang Xinzhou had also reassured Liang Shi that he would keep an eye on Liang Xinran.

If Liang Xinran had bought this hot search just to destroy the reputation she had only just restored, that would be too brainless.

This was practically a case of killing one thousand enemies while losing eight hundred of your own.¹

Liang Shi first scanned through the comments under the trending topic.

It was obvious that people were still stirring up trouble. Several marketing accounts had compiled Liang Xinran's previous Weibo posts and photos to compare the living circumstances of Liang Shi and Liang Xinran.

This truly drummed up a wave of hatred against Liang Shi.

[No wonder no one could dig up this girl's background. Turns out she's a fake heiress.]

[Tsk tsk, how can she be so self-righteous after stealing someone else's life? Is she really that shameless?]

[If I were her, I'd immediately leave the industry, okay? How does she have the nerve to compete with the real heiress for family and resources?]

[I genuinely feel sorry for Liang Xinran. My silly beauty, sob sob sob.]

[.....]

In the story netizens imagined, Liang Shi was the pampered heiress who got everything she wanted. For all these years, she had been an idle good-for-nothing in a wealthy family, yet still enjoyed the care of her parents and older brothers. Meanwhile, Liang Xinran had suffered harsh treatment in some godforsaken backwater;² lost her parents early, and depended on her seriously ill grandmother for survival. Because of lack of money, she couldn't even attend university.

The contrast was too stark.

Netizens condemned Liang Shi one after another, even denying her acting skills in the process.

This also triggered a wave of refund requests for "Journey of the Heart."

Even the person in charge of "Lingering Light" called Chang Hui, beating around the bush to ask whether this matter was true.

Chang Hui could only give a vague response.

Chang Hui had been in this industry for many years and had some connections. But after asking many journalist friends, no one knew where this information had leaked from, nor who had bought the hot search.

They could only trace the marketing account that initially broke the news to someone who used to be an anti-fan of Zhao Ying.

If the leak was because Liang Shi was close to Zhao Ying, how did that person know about the matter between Liang Shi and Liang Xinran?

And they even had the guts to expose it, making it trend within an hour.

This was definitely organized.

Using Liang Shi as a target to get revenge on Zhao Ying—the motive made sense, but the logic didn't.

Just as Liang Shi was still searching for the reason, Xu Qingzhu's side had already made progress. The final target was identified—Sun Chengcheng.

Liang Shi: "....."

This information came from Lu Jiayi telling Xu Qingzhu. Lu Jiayi was able to find this out thanks to her fiancée Fu You, who was a top student who had graduated with a degree in information technology. She directly hacked into the Weibo account that broke the news, and without any moral qualms, invaded the other party's computer to obtain chat records, then identified the person by searching accounts.

Of course, Lu Jiayi didn't tell Xu Qingzhu all this.

Lu Jiayi only gave the information to Xu Qingzhu. When Xu Qingzhu asked how she found out, she hesitated for two seconds before saying: "Fu You had someone look into it."

"Thanks," Xu Qingzhu had no intention of asking more. "I'll have Liang Shi treat you both to dinner another day."

Lu Jiayi smiled lightly: "It was nothing."

Meanwhile, on the other side of the city, Liang Xinran had just finished recording a new episode of "Let's Go Right Now."

She had landed in Haizhou less than an hour ago. From morning to night, she had been busy the entire time and hadn't even had a hot meal.

Having finally returned to Haizhou, she went directly to a restaurant under Dongheng's name.

But just as the food arrived and she picked up her chopsticks, before she could even grab a bite, she heard a stern shout: "Liang Xinran!"

Liang Xinran's hand trembled, and the food fell onto the table. She looked up toward the doorway.

Liang Xinhe, full of fury, walked toward her. He slapped one hand on the table and said coldly: "I really underestimated you."

Liang Xinran's brows furrowed slightly. Her eyes carried fear as she lightly pressed her lips together: "Second Brother... what are you talking about?"

"Still pretending?" Liang Xinhe scoffed. "A-Shi has already left the Liang family. She's not using the Liang family's resources now, and she hasn't threatened your position as the Liang family's Third Miss. Why must you drive her to extinction?"

Liang Xinran: "?"

"I don't understand." Liang Xinran looked confused. "Second Brother, what do you mean?"

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1. A Chinese idiom meaning a pyrrhic victory—winning but suffering severe losses in the process. ⇐
 2. The original Chinese phrase "雞不生蛋鳥不拉屎" literally means "a place where chickens don't lay eggs and birds don't shit"—a colorful expression describing an extremely remote, desolate, and underdeveloped place. ⇐

Chapter 173-2

Slap—

Liang Xinhe's hand slammed on the table again, causing the bowls and plates to shake and clatter.

The private room was deathly quiet. Liang Xinran's breathing seemed to freeze. She looked up at Liang Xinhe, and only after a moment did she say: "I... I..."

"You what." Liang Xinhe sneered. "I actually believed you when you said entering the entertainment industry was to find something you liked doing. What a waste that I helped you with all my heart. Big Brother didn't want you to do it, but I protected you. I treated you like a sister, and you?"

Liang Xinran froze, and tears began streaming down her face.

Liang Xinhe glanced at her sideways: "Big Brother was right. You came back just to compete."

"Compete for what?" Liang Xinran said aggrievedly. "What could I possibly compete for by entering the entertainment industry? The family business belongs to you and Big Brother. I've never had any designs on it. I know Mom and Dad feel guilty toward me and want to compensate me, but I don't want to see you all unhappy because of me. I've already moved out, and I can support myself. I already had a management contract before. I'm just continuing the life I had before. What did I do wrong?"

After speaking through tears, Liang Xinran raised her hand to wipe her tears and turned around to pretend to be strong, but her shoulders kept heaving—she was obviously crying.

Liang Xinhe's heart softened at her words, and for a moment he didn't know what to do.

Liang Xinran sniffled. "I know I'm not worthy of the Liang family. The education you all received from childhood is different from mine. My family was poor, and I could only rely on myself. I never thought about doing anything at the Liang family. But all these years, I just wanted my parents. What did I do wrong? I finally managed to add some shine to my broken life. I can finally stop going hungry. I can finally leave that small village and come to a big city. This was the path I was already fighting desperately to walk. How did it suddenly become me competing?"

Liang Xinran smiled bitterly: "Do I have to leave Haizhou and return to that life without any hope for it to be right? I don't understand."

Liang Xinhe was momentarily speechless.

Liang Xinran sighed softly: "I so wish you were all just ordinary office workers. I just want a family, that's all. But now nothing is simple, and it seems like I can't do anything. If you think it will only end when I return to where I came from, then I'll just go back."

Liang Xinran sat back down, turned around, picked up her spoon to eat, and lowered her eyes.

Though her voice was choked with sobs, she forced herself to appear strong: "I'll explain to Mom and Dad. I won't involve you. As for the entertainment industry, I won't do it anymore. I'll cancel my Weibo account too. In the future... I'll go back home to farm."

Liang Xinhe suddenly panicked: "That's not what I meant."

"I understand everything now." Liang Xinran swallowed her food but choked on it, looking pitiful and miserable. She said: "I really, truly won't appear before any of you again in the future, or even in Haizhou. My life will probably just have to end in that small village. This is my fate. I accept it."

Liang Xinhe suddenly didn't know what to say.

He had come to confront Liang Xinran, but because of these few sentences from her, all his anger dissipated and he couldn't say anything.

After a long while, Liang Xinhe finally asked: "It really wasn't you?"

"I have no idea what happened." Liang Xinran wiped her tears. "If you want to say it was me, then fine, it was me. Even if I say it wasn't, you won't believe me anyway."

Liang Xinhe: "....."

Liang Xinhe frowned, then answered a phone call. After hanging up, he said awkwardly: "Then you eat first. I'll go investigate."

After Liang Xinhe left, Liang Xinran spat out what she was chewing into the trash can, picked up her phone to check the hot search, and frowned when she saw the top few trending topics. She immediately switched to another number and called Zhang Yangning.

The call connected quickly. It was noisy on the other end.

Liang Xinran said angrily: "What are you doing? Who told you to leak the information to the media? Didn't I tell you? Wait until I say to leak it before leaking!"

Zhang Yangning's voice was lazy, sounding like he had been drinking too much. "Babe, what are you angry about? It wasn't me who leaked it."

Liang Xinran: "Why don't you just drink yourself to death."

Liang Xinran lit a cigarette, and blue-gray smoke dispersed before her eyes.

"How could I die?" Zhang Yangning chuckled. "You've seen today's hot search, right? It wasn't me."

"Then how did it suddenly get exposed? I already told you, Liang Xinzhou is keeping a close eye on me. The previous matter almost gave him something to hold against me. He can't find out about my relationship with you, otherwise we're both finished." Liang Xinran was furious. "Have you forgotten how you lost your job?"

"Bad luck." Zhang Yangning gritted his teeth at the memory, scoffing lightly. "How long are you going to be afraid of them?"

"I don't know." Liang Xinran said. "Liang Xinzhou is very vigilant right now. I entered the entertainment industry precisely to make him let his guard down. By the way, you said today's incident wasn't your doing—then who was it?"

Besides her, who else wanted to ruin Liang Shi's reputation?

"The one who acted alongside Liang Shi." Zhang Yangning chuckled. "I just... did a little tampering."

Liang Xinran: "....."

Zhang Yangning laughed even more brazenly: "That idiot fell for it. Don't worry, you just need to play your part well at the Liang family. You don't know anything anyway. Even if they keep investigating, they won't trace it back to you."

Liang Xinran froze for a moment, then threatened: "It better be that way."

Chapter 173-3

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After learning that Sun Chengcheng was behind it, everything made sense.

After all, stepping on a fellow actress after working together was something she was quite skilled at.

It's just that before she stepped on people directly, and now she had switched to a different method.

Liang Shi wasn't in a hurry to resolve this matter. She first went to ask Gu Yixue.

Gu Yixue wasn't concerned. For her, box office revenue was just a bonus anyway.

She had never planned to get rich off box office earnings.

However, having someone from the same production cause this kind of trouble was indeed vexing.

It felt like being stabbed in the back.

Yet Gu Yixue couldn't come forward to say anything, especially since Sun Chengcheng had done all this behind the scenes.

It wasn't exactly lying either.

It's just that Liang Shi's identity, which she had hidden for so long, was suddenly exposed, so she had to acknowledge it.

It was frustrating, but there was no other choice.

Liang Shi had Chang Hui release a statement, but it was just a drop in the bucket.¹

It didn't make the public opinion completely dissipate.

It was later that Liang Xinzhou registered a Weibo account overnight, got it verified, and then posted a pinned message.

@Liang Xinzhou: Liang Shi's surname is Liang, right? @Liang Shi.

Publicly showing his support for Liang Shi.

His second Weibo post was: Liang Xinran's surname is also Liang. @Liang Xinran.

This was essentially telling everyone: They're both my sisters, there's no need to compete.

Meanwhile, Chang Hui's PR team also took action, guiding the narrative online and steering public opinion toward "having your life switched at birth wasn't something she wanted either."

The matter finally settled down, but Liang Shi's identity could no longer be hidden.

Everyone started examining her interactions with Liang Xinran on the variety show under a magnifying glass.

In any case, she was trending on hot search every day—the production team didn't even need to buy it.

Fortunately, "Journey of the Heart" wasn't affected much.

Liang Shi arranged to meet with Sun Chengcheng.

At that time, Sun Chengcheng had just announced an endorsement deal and simultaneously announced a drama—an S+ project from a well-known team.

She was doing quite well for herself.

After all, in the original world, with her level, she probably couldn't even get a supporting female role in an S+ project, let alone the female lead.

When Liang Shi saw her, she first leisurely poured a cup of tea, her eyes lowered, looking very gentle.

"What do you want with me?" Sun Chengcheng asked. "There shouldn't be anything for us to talk about, right?"

Liang Shi smiled lightly: "Is that so?"

Sun Chengcheng froze for a moment, then continued with a cold face: "What else?"

"Sun Chengcheng." Liang Shi stared at her. "You've become more and more skilled at throwing dirty water on fellow actresses in your productions."

Sun Chengcheng's expression changed slightly but quickly recovered. She played dumb to the end: "What are you talking about? I don't understand."

Liang Shi sneered: "You don't need to understand."

As soon as the words left her mouth, a cup of tea was splashed on Sun Chengcheng's face, catching her completely off guard.

Sun Chengcheng was stunned, then screamed. But Liang Shi leisurely adjusted her sleeve, and a few seconds later, another cup of tea was splashed over.

Tea leaves stuck to Sun Chengcheng's face.

"Liang Shi! Have you gone crazy?!" Sun Chengcheng shouted.

Liang Shi nodded, smiled, her eyes carrying a mocking gleam: "The first cup is a toast to you for the previous exposé, stepping on me by claiming I sexually harassed you."

Sun Chengcheng's eyes immediately changed. "You... you you..."

She was so shocked that she couldn't even complete her sentences.

But Liang Shi continued with a smile on her lips: "The second cup is a toast to you for exposing my identity this time, stepping on a fellow actress again during the release of 'Journey of the Heart.'"

Sun Chengcheng was so stunned she couldn't speak.

But Liang Shi raised her hand and splashed another cup.

"I used to think that taking a step back would lead to a broader horizon."² Liang Shi smiled lightly. "But now I've realized that when I take a step back, you just push forward even more."

"This cup is a warning to you. If there's a next time, I will definitely make you leave the industry for good." Liang Shi set the teacup down heavily on the table. "I'm different from before. You know that."

"So what?!" Sun Chengcheng shouted. "You just married the heiress of Minghui Jewelry! Without Dongheng's protection, what are you?! What gives you the right to make me leave the industry?!"

"Just the fact that I married the heiress of Minghui Jewelry... no wait, she's now the CEO of Minghui Jewelry." Liang Shi said. "To deal with a minor celebrity, isn't Minghui Jewelry enough? Do I even need Dongheng? Do you think you're worthy of that?"

Sun Chengcheng: "....."

"You... you knew I was Sun Chengcheng from the beginning, didn't you?" Sun Chengcheng suddenly realized.

"Yes, from the moment I first saw you." Liang Shi said. "Because a detestable aura can't be hidden."

Sun Chengcheng was shocked, but a few seconds later, Liang Shi suddenly smiled: "Oh right, your career ends today."

"What do you mean?" Sun Chengcheng was confused.

Liang Shi waved her phone. "See for yourself."

After saying this, Liang Shi stood up to leave. Sun Chengcheng quickly glanced at her phone and saw a trending topic: #Sun Chengcheng Breach of Contract#.

Gu Yixue had directly had her studio's legal team send a lawyer's letter. When Gu Yixue signed contracts with actors, it included a clause that during the release period of "Journey of the Heart," they could not do anything detrimental to the film.

This was something Gu Yixue always included in her contracts—covering illegal activities, moral corruption, chaotic private life, backstabbing colleagues in the same production, unauthorized marketing purchases, and so on.

And Sun Chengcheng had breached the contract.

At the same time, someone leaked that Sun Chengcheng had been frequenting a certain club—a place notorious for being a male escort establishment.³

This added another label of "chaotic private life" to her name.

Sun Chengcheng was shocked: "No... I only went there to find someone."

Liang Shi smiled: "That I wouldn't know."

Sun Chengcheng's eyes were practically bulging: "Liang Shi! You!"

"Give someone a taste of their own medicine."⁴ Liang Shi stood up, her tone becoming increasingly nonchalant. "I originally wanted to give you a chance to start over here, but you had no such intention. So let it end at the beginning."

After saying this, she walked out.

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1. "杯水車薪" (a cup of water to put out a burning cart of firewood) is a Chinese idiom meaning an utterly inadequate measure or a drop in the bucket. ⇐
 2. "退一步海闊天空" is a Chinese proverb meaning "take a step back and the sea and sky will open up"—essentially, yielding or being tolerant will lead to better outcomes. ⇐
 3. "鴨子店" literally means "duck shop." In Chinese slang, "鴨子" (duck) refers to male escorts or male prostitutes, similar to how "雞" (chicken) is slang for female prostitutes. ⇐
 4. "以其人之道還治其人之身" is a Chinese idiom meaning to use someone's own methods against them—essentially, to give someone a taste of their own medicine. ⇐

Chapter 173-4

Those photos and dirt on Sun Chengcheng were all released by people Xu Qingzhu had arranged.

The photos were also taken after Xu Qingzhu had lured her there, but Sun Chengcheng had no evidence to prove it.

And all of Sun Chengcheng's media accounts were banned overnight.

All the contracts that had been finalized were terminated.

When Liang Shi walked out of the restaurant, Xu Qingzhu was taking a stroll by the roadside. Liang Shi immediately jogged over and asked in a low voice: "Why aren't you waiting in the car?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled lightly: "I need to walk around more. Sitting all the time makes my back ache."

"Then shall I walk with you a bit longer?" Liang Shi asked.

"Let's go home," Xu Qingzhu said.

The two didn't linger outside for too long. After returning to their residential complex, they took another stroll.

Xu Qingzhu asked how she had handled things.

Liang Shi teased: "Waving Teacher Xu's banner, naturally everything went smoothly."

"I didn't do anything," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi wrapped her arm around her waist. "Having you by my side is enough."

Xu Qingzhu was still worried about her future and sighed: "This industry is so chaotic."

"No," Liang Shi said. "It's people's hearts that are chaotic."

Liang Shi shrugged: "She never took the right path before. She always thought that pulling others down would help her climb up. But actually, even without me, there would still be others competing with her. She never thinks about improving her own professional skills, but instead puts effort into underhanded methods. That's why she ended up like this."

"But I still don't want to see you suffer." Xu Qingzhu pulled her to sit on a bench downstairs in their complex, her voice soft: "Your life has already been hard enough."

"No, it hasn't." Liang Shi smiled lightly, comforting her. "Do you have some misunderstanding about me?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her from the side. She was still smiling gently, with the brightest stars in her eyes.

Liang Shi said unhurriedly: "I have you, and now I also have babies. I have a family—how could life be hard? If work is hard, then you must be working many times harder than me."

Liang Shi hugged her, stroking her head, her silky long hair winding around her fingers: "I already feel guilty that I can't share the risks and discomfort of pregnancy with you. Don't worry about me anymore. Take good care of yourself."

"What about you?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

"Are you taking good care of yourself?"

Liang Shi paused for a few seconds, turned her head and met her gaze directly. She leaned down and kissed the corner of her lips, saying with a light smile: "Of course. I still have to take good care of all of you."

"Is it mainly me or them?" Xu Qingzhu asked, pointing at her belly.

Liang Shi blinked, not answering immediately.

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Alright, I understand. It's mainly taking care of your babies."

Liang Shi: "?"

She really didn't expect Xu Qingzhu to get jealous over this.

Liang Shi didn't know whether to laugh or cry. She immediately explained: "It's mainly you. Those two... we haven't even met them yet, what feelings could there be?"

"So you're saying that after we meet them and have feelings, they'll become more important?"

"No." Liang Shi immediately denied it. She raised her hand and gently tapped her forehead, her tone helpless yet indulgent: "You, honestly."

"What?" Xu Qingzhu's eyes were clear and bright. "Tell me the truth—who do you love most?"

Liang Shi glanced around. No one was passing by. Bewitched by her adorable little expression, she couldn't look away at all. Taking advantage of the fact that no one was around, she felt an itch in her heart and leaned in to give her a kiss.

Then she leaned close to her ear and coaxed in a low voice: "It's you, my baby."

After saying this, her ears turned red first, but feeling it wasn't enough, she added: "My adorable little wife."